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Against straight-forwardness: Literary twists and queer communality in Shani Mootoo's *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab*

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ABSTRACT
This article considers how Shani Mootoo's ([2014] 2017) *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* avoids essentializing identity by employing queer literary twists. These twists are read as mimicking their counterpart in queer social relations; namely, how queers reorient human belonging away from a shared identity, towards a queer communality of connection through difference. This approach is used to suggest why queerness is important for the global reach of anti-colonial praxes not to become segregated by identity. Sara Ahmed's conception of "queer use" informs an understanding that, to be fully actualized, anti-colonial praxes and queer resistance must be entwined. This article examines the macrosocial queer scope of Mootoo's writing, which in turn supports nascent critical insights related to globally focused queer critique and anglophone Caribbean writing. In this context, twisting is proposed as a queer literary mode that disorients the straightness of accepted perspectives on resistance to colonialism and postcolonial freedoms.

KEYWORDS
Queer; anti-colonial; Caribbean; global; communality; disorientation

The literary twists of Shani Mootoo (2017) *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* (first published in 2014) produce disorientations of existing social structures. These have contemporary resonance for queer resistance strategies against a global straight status quo, consistent with the understanding, expressed by queer Trinidadian writer Shivanee Ramlochan (2020), that "reading the Caribbean means you read the world" (n.p.). For example, the twist of Caribbean writing has the potential for global impacts by acting against straight-forward conventions of identity and community as tools for resistance. Queer writing functions in a forward and sideways movement, as a twist, to disorient a straight status quo shared amongst the global condition of anti-queerness. This movement exists without a shared identity or similarity, meaning no shared topic, form, genre, tone, style, focus, or otherwise. Also, its reformulated view of solidarity transcends an idealization of community based around an identity; instead, solidarity is understood as a communality against the straight-forwardness of any predefined identity structure. Mootoo's representation of a queer family, and her use of narrative form, amount to

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a twist that disorients the definition of familiar and conventional constructions in contemporary anglophone writing. This twist, I propose, can engender broader possibilities for viewing queer bonds not as unfamiliar or unconventional, but as the core of human connections themselves: unique, different, ineffable, and multiform.

Disorientation is key to José Esteban Muñoz's (2009) description of queer theorizing: "a conceptual grid in which we do not claim to always already know queerness in the world" (22). That is, queer theorizing is maintaining the unknown, ineffable, and undefinable nature of queerness; to keep queer slippery and disorienting, and not form a queer "identity" assimilated into existing social structures. This thinking twists – forward and sideways – the British colonial imposition of racial, gender, and sexual difference in relation to the anglophone Caribbean. The oppressive violence of socially prescribed identity imposed on the Caribbean via colonialism highlights the counter-intuitive action of continuing to group around these categorizations. I argue that critiquing the action of grouping around identity also aids in revealing the practices necessary for global relations to be forged through individual difference and not in categories prescribed by a colonial, postcolonial, or nationalist source. These terms – "colonial", "postcolonial", or "nationalist" – remain fluid in this article to highlight that there can arguably be no agreed fixed boundaries to their temporal and critical limits or their definitional parameters.

At the same time, my interpretation acknowledges the different experiences of oppression related to identity. This entails acknowledging the reality of societal oppressions experienced by a person due to their identity, whilst twisting against the essentializing of identity (that is, attributing to an identity an intrinsic characteristic, value, or worth). I suggest that twisting against such essentializing includes an embrace of "time and habits and ways" being constantly and consistently "shifted forward and backwards and sideways" (Mootoo 2017, 45), to elude categorization by the straight status quo as an identity vulnerable to oppression or domination. Following a contextual introduction surrounding queerness, Mootoo, and positionality, I offer a close reading of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* to explore twisting as a mode of queer communality.

Literary bodies: Living and writing queerly

The queer twists in the narrative of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* include the transnational movement of multiple characters through a queer Caribbean diaspora. Though born in Ireland, Mootoo similarly undertook transnational movements across regions of the British Commonwealth. A queer Caribbean diaspora refers to the preponderance of LGBT+ and queer Caribbean citizens who seek asylum in Commonwealth countries, especially in Canada. As Edward Ou Jun Lee and Shari Brotman (2011) explain, "in 1991, Canada became one of the first Western nations to grant refugee status on the basis of sexual orientation" (242). In their sociological insights on queer migration, Lee and Brotman further explain that "1,351 SOGI [sexual orientation and gender identity] based refugee claims were adjudicated in 2004" (2011, 242). As a same-sex-desiring Trinidadian woman who expatriated to Canada in her late teens, Shani Mootoo remains a part of this unique queer Caribbean movement. David A.B. Murray (2015), writing on SOGI-based migration to Canada, notes that "the vast majority of participants (over 90 percent)" in his Canadian research group "were from Caribbean or African nations" (11). Arooran Ananthavel Murugan's (2024) multi-author review on the mental

health needs of Canadian SOGI refugees claims that "a growing number" of SOGI-"status persons are seeking refuge in Canada" and that "70.5 percent of claims" based on SOGI status "were granted, compared to 62.5 percent for all others" (56). The presumption that queer freedom is made more possible in countries outside the Caribbean is also aptly critiqued by Murray as the trope of "*queer migration to liberation nation*" (2015, 3; emphasis in original). I complicate this trope by proposing anti-queerness as a global condition, where the rules of engagement in a straight status quo differ in different geopolitical and geosocial locations, but the ethos of straight conformity remains as much a global as a local demand. The ideation of foreign freedom is uneven in terms of the ability to live certain expressions of queerness more openly, although this of course still involves the navigation of prejudice regardless of geographical location. However, the ability to think of queer freedom as supposedly "better" in a specific global location can also create the comfort of a hopeful imaginary, which supports queer lives, and which is of no less importance for being hoped for and imagined.

I interpret this queer Caribbean movement in relation to Sara Ahmed's (2019) conception of "queer use", meaning "how things can be used in ways other than for which they were intended or by those other than for whom they were intended" (199). A queer use of colonial legacies, including the Commonwealth, sees them twisted into an opportunity for queer people. I suggest that this queer movement informs Mootoo's writing as presenting a queer perspective in Caribbean Canadian diasporic writing, and that her body of work twists away from conventional understandings of anti-colonial resistance that often do not centralize queerness. My view is informed by a reorientation of queer Caribbean writer Thomas Glave's (2013) observation that diasporic literature "doesn't just provide information about the diaspora – it *is* the diaspora" (40; emphasis in original). In the context of my critical focus, the queer literary body of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* is thus not simply information about global queer literary resistance; rather, it is itself a global queer literary resistance. As Ronald Cummings and Njelle Hamilton (2021) comment, "queerness and Caribbeanness – *Caribbeing* – might actually be synonymous" (4; emphasis in original). My reading supports Rinaldo Walcott's (2015) interpretation of Sylvia Wynter's oeuvre, surrounding being human as praxis, that the Caribbean is "a space of unique invention in the colonial and modern world" which "has much to offer contemporary global culture on living difference as central to humanness" (194). In this article, I suggest that the "unique invention" of "living difference" (Walcott 2015, 194) includes the importance of queer Caribbean literary resistance in transnational terms.

Contentious queerness

My use of the term "queer" related to anglophone Caribbean writing will be contentious, as well it should remain. For example, Rosamond S. King (2014) has critiqued the term "queer" as white-centric whilst inviting further critical commentary and debate on the subject. In the context of *The Queer Caribbean Speaks*, King writes that she is "not sure about your [the editor's] use of the term *queer*" because "it is hardly used in the region" and "its use in the USA is directly related to age, class, and education" (153; emphasis in original). This view has conceptual crossovers with the use of the neologism *cuir*, in place of queer, in Hispanophone Caribbean studies. Sayak Valencia and Olga Arnaiz

Zhuravleva (2019) explain that "*cuir* represents an *ostranienie* [defamiliarization] of the term queer" which "registers the geopolitical inflection towards the South" (190). However, I view a change from one colonial lingua franca to another, from English to Spanish, as maintaining the same problematics. Thus, critical contentions surrounding the use of the term "queer" in Caribbean literary contexts, related to white supremacy, coupled with the popular global reach that the term "queer" has garnered particularly over the last decade, can also aid fresh interpretations of queerness, Caribbeanness, and the coloniality of straightness related to categorized identity.

A view that the term "queer" is white-centric is well founded, yet it can also shroud the reality that this was catalysed through mishandling by a dominant Anglo American and Eurocentric academic system. If the term "queer" has been reappropriated from its use as a slur by straight people, then I propose that it contains the capacity also to be reoriented away from white supremacy. My conceptual framing of queer Caribbean communality as a global literary resistance continually returns to the slipperiness of what queerness is, as a major strength and justification for the validity of its use in globally focused critique. Important issues surrounding white supremacy entwined with the term "queer" must draw careful and continued considerations and reflection, but I maintain that the unique transgressions, which make Mootoo's writing of worldly importance, lie in the queerness of defying reductions to an identity. This is because queerness is at its core a commitment to a continuing series of "disidentifications" (cf. Muñoz 1999), which "tactically and simultaneously works on, with, and against a cultural form" (12), rather than queerness being absorbed into, or attached onto, a categorized form of identity.

To clarify, I do not understand the straightness of straight-forwardness only as cisgender heterosexuality but as a metonym for the global status quo of white supremacy that is intrinsically anti-queer. Regarding the Caribbean, the links between anti-queerness and white supremacy stem from colonial-era social oppressions. So, for example, present-day homophobia and transphobia in the Caribbean can be viewed as "white" insofar as they are closely associated with colonialism. This reality is a lens through which to view the many variations of bigotry as a straight-forwardness which fuels the current global status quo of white supremacy: racism is straight, transphobia is straight, misogyny is straight, and so on.

A contentious queerness exists within the global disruption created by Shani Mootoo's Caribbean writing through her novel *Cereus Blooms at Night* (Mootoo 1996). Alison Donnell's (2011) explanation that the novel extended "the vocabulary and repertoire of images" which were not previously "available in Caribbean writing" (4) supports *Cereus Blooms at Night* as one of the progenitors for Caribbean literary transgressors of global straight norms. The novel also remains one of a minority of texts by a person of colour from the Global South that is taught worldwide in queer literary studies courses. However, *Cereus Blooms at Night* did not achieve canonical status without critical contentions, including accusations of appropriation, as it adopts the narrative perspective of an African Trinidadian gay man that can be read to represent his gayness as part of a gender dysphoria expressed by his trans-vestitism. The separation of gayness from gender dysphoria, which is also distinct from transvestitism, is blurred in *Cereus Blooms at Night*, where these expressions are brought together in a way that can be read to conflate them. A similar contemporary criticism has been levelled against Mootoo's trans male protagonist in *Moving*

Forward Sideways Like a Crab, which has recently been unpacked through the opposing positions of literary scholar Lisa Outar (2017) and poet Casey Plett (2015). Outar has argued that Mootoo's "presentation of female-to-male transition" in *Moving Forward Like a Crab* is shifted "to a representation that is quite a bit more complex" and "fully fleshed" than *Cereus Blooms at Night* (247). In contrast, Plett has placed *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* within an emergent genre she dubs "the Gender novel", a designation referring to texts that "fail to communicate what it's actually like to transition" (n.p.). I agree with aspects of both arguments whilst highlighting my support for Mootoo's statement, in an interview with Mariam Pirbhai, that *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* "is as advanced for its time as *Cereus Blooms at Night* was for its" (Mootoo 2015, 234). However, the knowledge that *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* is advanced for "its time" remains a critique of "its time" in the contemporary world. I suggest that, because of the global condition of anti-queerness, trans narratives are often flattened into a homogenous experience. This includes the lack of literary platforms and opportunities for multiple differing trans stories in writing. So, I see *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* as advanced for its time, but this remains a critique of the global condition of anti-queerness, rather than casting Mootoo as a uniquely or exceptionally progressive writer.

My position as a white British queer researcher in this field is itself a form of contentious queerness, but also remains part of my argument within a discourse which confronts identity as a categorizing force. However, I must also pay careful heed to the reality that although categories of identity are socially constructed, they do create different levels of violence against each queer person differently. My positionality seeks to demonstrate a way of recognizing the very real differences of oppression related to identity, without viewing this as an end point to the conversation about where and how queer connections can be made. My positionality may fail to transcend the limits of cultural and identity differences for some, but if queerness loves anything it is an artful failure. Using my contentious queer position, I foreground Paul Gilroy's (2019) perspective that "racism *generates* or assembles races", meaning a need to "demand liberation, not from white supremacy alone, but from all racializing and raciological thought" (188; emphasis in original). Further, I follow Caryl Phillips's (2012) view on "master narratives" of identity and community that continue to "include some people and exclude others", pointing to the need to "change the narrative" (n.p.). This changed narrative can arguably be found in the position of queer communality beyond the inclusions and exclusions of identity categories. A foundation for queer communality can be understood through queer Caribbean writer Nalo Hopkinson's (2014) belief, expressed in an interview, that "I don't much fit in anywhere" being "queer, not gay or lesbian" (161); that is, there are connections shared globally by all those who also "don't much fit in anywhere": to any identity or any community. Shani Mootoo's own perspective holds that queers should not assimilate to an identity for "the sake of a pretend shared community, no matter how lonely one is", as this cannot happen "without going insane" (Mootoo 2015, 231). Thus, I maintain that queer individuality does not equate with a straight-forward idea of individualism, because it remains a communal invitation to exist in connection whilst retaining full personal autonomy. I argue that *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* turns away from the continuation of a colonial mindset informing the global condition of anti-queerness.

Defamiliarizing familiarity

Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab presents the fictional life narrative of trans man Sydney (Syd) Mahale. This involves Syd's shift from being identified by a straight status quo as an Indian Trinidadian woman, Siddhani (Sid) Mahale, and later as the Indian Trinidadian man he has always been. This shift is related to identification by a straight status quo, rather than an essentialized binary change from woman to man, because Sid and Syd are entwined throughout the narrative. The novel adopts a first-person perspective from Syd in its short initial section, "From Sydney's Notebook" (Mootoo 2017, 19–25), and from Syd's stepson Jonathan in sections of "Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab: A Memoir by Jonathan Lewis-Adey" (27–302). The majority of this larger section of narrative is, however, told through an indirect third-person perspective by Jonathan, but "(as he [Syd] told it to me)" (Mootoo 2017, 67), transcribed from Syd's deathbed. Syd's life is chronicled in a non-linear temporal, spatial, and narrative fashion between Trinidad and Toronto, including Siddhani's early adulthood and her unrequited love for her closest female friend Zain who is later murdered by her male partner. Part two opens with the representation of Sid's solo walk to the gender clinic, which is retold multiply in the narrative; this ends with the revelation that Sid's motivation for transitioning gender was to escape misogyny. This escape is not defined by the safety obtained from becoming a male in a misogynistic world, but rather by the safety of being identified as a male by a misogynistic straight status quo. Thus, the representation of gender transition in the novel is further twisted away from a fixed split of Sid and Syd: Sid has always been Syd. At Syd's funeral, Jonathan receives letters between Sid and Zain from which he proceeds to write a romantic metanarrative of their love story that is presented as the climactic section of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab*.

The narrative structure of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* informs the movement of its literary twisting, which allows it to create meandering pathways against straight-forwardness. I read these pathways as traces of Derridean "destinerrance" as interpreted by Jean-Luc Nancy and Peter Engelmann (2019). Nancy and Engelmann read "destinerrance" as a "destiny" which is not only "destin" – as in predetermined purpose – "but destiny as errance, as aimless wandering" (26). The literary twists of Mootoo's novel constitute a narrative disorientation that is a written version of "errance, as aimless wandering", where the "aimless" or ineffable qualities of queerness allow it to defy the conception that straightness is familiar. This is important because familiarity can arguably be seen as a categorizing tool in aid of the global condition of anti-queerness.

Defamiliarizing familiarity in *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* can be understood as aimless but no less impactful for not having a set destination. That is, the act of twisting in literary disorientation stems here from writing in English, on queer themes, and from a Caribbean perspective. From this vantage point, queerness and Caribbeanness, in their relationship to English, become synonymous because they both always and already include the other, in an additional twist against the straightness remnant in "nation language" as conceived by Kamau Brathwaite. Brathwaite (1984) coined "nation language" in answer to his own vital question: "can English be a revolutionary language?" (311). In this context, nation language means that Caribbean English, as separate and distinct from Creole languages across the Caribbean, is English "in terms of its lexical features", but "in its contours, its rhythm

and timbre, its sound explosions, it is not English" (Brathwaite 1984, 311). However, to achieve a macrosocial anti-colonial resistance, ideas of nation language necessitate a further queer twist. This is because literary twists remain necessary as a self-protection for queers, as resistance against the seemingly benign familiarity of straight-forwardness which demands that queers conform to some version of identity. To obtain this autonomy, queer writing twists the preconceptions of normative orientation that both inform, and are informed by, a societal status quo of straightness. Defying anti-transness as inseparable from fighting anti-queerness is important because, as Francisco J. Galarte (2021) explains, this is what "the prefix 'trans-' does; it infers movement across, crossing, beyond, and through" (10). In the Caribbean, this straightness is a distinctive remnant of colonialism, as much as it remains in the straight nationalist dominance of (supposedly ex-)colonial and neocolonial countries. Anti-queerness in any location is only ever a reflection of a global reality: straightening difference and essentializing straight-forwardness as a singular norm. This straightening device demands that the unnatural constructs of racism and heterosexism, amid an unquestioning conformity to a prescribed identity of race, gender, and sexuality, be viewed as the untransgressed norm because of their familiarity. The trans prefix remains relevant for *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* related to its transgression of gender change as a binary destination (to woman or to man) being validated by surgical intervention. Although Syd undergoes gender reassignment surgery, he remains entwined with Sid throughout the narrative, which means that Sid is not surgically erased. The desire for Syd's gender transition remains queer because it is based on personal safety amid a critique of misogyny – because of gender identification by a straight status quo – and not a medical validation for Syd's gender. The fear of this transgression is pivotal to the importance of trans freedoms for queer resistance, as anti-trans bigotry is inseparable from the global condition of anti-queerness.

Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab twists against the global condition of anti-queerness, that is anti-trans, by highlighting a lack of criticality surrounding the familiarity of family structures. A straight-forward family line is twisted to separate the concept of familiarity from the straight-forward norm of a family unit. Each representation of Sid's and Syd's family remains twisted in multiple, unfamiliarly errant, forms in such a way that the familiarity of family units can be viewed as conditional to normative, straight-forward, definitions, but that they are also never an essential norm. As Sid transitions gender to Syd, so too does their family unit become disoriented as a mother becomes a father but remains a mother; however, these categories remain familiar even though they lose their claim to a straight norm. Jonathan explains that although his family is changed by Syd's gender transition, its form remains familiar because, while "the material, the physical form of the past" as he "had known it, had changed utterly, the heart of it was steady and true" (Mootoo 2017, 39). Jonathan's understanding of the "steady and true" (39) connections which exist beyond a straight-forward family unit combats what Sara Ahmed explains as a linearity of "compulsory heterosexuality" which "operates as a straightening device" (2006, 23). In terms of anglophone Caribbean literature this "straightening device" informs and is informed by the dominant modes of Anglo American or Eurocentric categories of narrative form. For example, the straightening of representation is created in following a familiar and straight-forward presentation of exposition, rising action, climax, falling action, and denouement.

Narrative linearity results in the straightening of characters and narratives, as well as their literary worlds, which means that disrupting this mode will always make way for something queerly new.

This queer newness also disrupts racialized binaries surrounding compulsory heterosexuality, whose lesser-examined aspects remain inherently racist – such as how the universal image of the nuclear family not only includes a heterosexual cisgender female mother, a heterosexual cisgender male father, and heterosexual cisgender children, but that they are also each white. I do not mean that a nuclear family unit is shared across cultures, because multiform expressions of the family exist; rather, the idea of a nuclear family unit is familiar across cultures because of its racist and colonial advent in the Caribbean and other colonized regions. By disrupting narrative linearity, the defamiliarizing of familiarity from straightness to queerness in *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* is achieved as a newness created by allowing non-normative representations of a family to thrive against the "straightening device" (Ahmed 2006, 23) of compulsory heterosexuality.

Compulsory heterosexuality, universalized as a societal construction, connects with Ronald Cummings's (2019) interpretation of "'here' as an oppressive space" (320) for queer people of colour, because both racism and straightness support white supremacy. As Ahmed notes, compulsory heterosexuality serves to keep people in line, globally, by proliferating and then policing the idea that life naturally moves towards a straight-forward "family line", with its "legitimacy and social capital of heteronormativity" (2006, 74), which aligns with the social capital of whiteness. *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab*, however, aids understandings of different ways to remain out of line but still familiar. Mootoo's text disrupts a nuclear, traditional, and straight-forward family line through a reconfigured familial unit that adds a further twist by remaining far from the straight norm whilst also not being defined in opposition to normality. This reconfigured family unit is informed by a trans freedom of expression underscoring the importance of trans understandings and relations to disorienting, and further defying, the global condition of anti-queerness. Similarly, micha cárdenas and Jian Neo Chen (2019) "do not presume queerness and transness to be separate" within a "decolonial trans of color figuration" (472), meaning that the trans family and the queering of family are interconnected because they each defy convention whilst refusing to be defined against convention. Family is family whatever its form: each iteration of family is different, unique, singular, and ineffable and cannot be defined in opposition to a straight norm.

Specific structures of the family differ across global cultures. For example, there is much scholarship on the prevalence of matrifocality in Caribbean family structures. Yet it is also true that contemporary family units include a familial norm that presupposes the binary of heterosexual cisgender members. As Olive Senior (1991) argues, this norm – as it operates across the anglophone Caribbean – is derived from Victorian England in an adherence to the "sexual division of labour in the domestic sphere and to patriarchal family structure" (102). Senior defines this norm in terms of family units and gender roles, but it also functions at the level of family members as cisgender and heterosexual in a direct link to the coloniality of straightness related to the Caribbean. In *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab*, the representation of a queer family twists the concept of familiar norms against themselves to reveal all family units as unique, singular in form, and normal, by reorienting gendered expectations of a mother. Jonathan's comment that Sid

"had once been my other mother" (Mootoo 2017, 123) allows mothering to defy straight-forwardness, because Sid as Jonathan's "other mother" includes the context of Sydney's sexual orientation and gender transition. Sid, as a queer other mother, complicates understandings of an othermother derived from a history of West African tribal traditions, and African American feminist theory. Othermothers are derived from West African traditions of the communal and provide care for children not biologically their own. Diane Watt (2004) contextualizes othermothers as part of "the way in which the community organizes to nurture itself and future generations" (195). However, engagements with othermothers remain defined by gender, biological sex, and cisgender identity, and *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* complicates this straight-forward binary of gender, sex, and motherhood related to othermothers because Syd has always existed as part of Sid. Mootoo's representation works against straight-forwardness by highlighting the gaps and faults of the English language when it comes to gender fluidity, making her novel a literary space for a twisted description that redefines mothering against an immutable gender binary because the boundaries of exactly where Sid ends and where Syd begins remain indeterminate. Therefore, Mootoo adds a twist on the term "mother" and the term "othermother" to defy a fixed sex binary. In a further engagement with Ahmed's "queer use", Mootoo's twist on a fixed female sex, ascribed to the words "mother" and "othermother", evidence Ahmed's assertion that "in the paths assumed to lead to cessation" there is "a chance of being in another way" (Ahmed 2019, 208). Mootoo's presentation uses the gaps and faults of English when it comes to a gender binary to depict "being in another way" without being defined as the other to straight norms.

The orientations of relationships in *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* have been interpreted by Libe García Zarranz (2020) as "sideways feelings", which they view as "oriented and reoriented through different forms of ethical encounters and modes of relationality" (94). For García Zarranz, these "sideways feelings" create "an ethico-affective lens which problematizes normative scripts and orientations" (94). In Mootoo's novel, the normative scripts of gender and sexuality as they relate to Sid's and Syd's Caribbeanness remain necessarily problematized by disorienting the idea of any single fixed norm, reflecting their need for disruption on a global level. This is illustrated in Syd's explanation that, because "there is hardly ever a single answer to anything", "the stories one most needs to know are the ones that are usually the least simple or straight-forward" (Mootoo 2017, 49). I agree with García Zarranz that *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* holds normativity up to an ethico-affective critique. But I further suggest that queerness and Caribbeanness interrelate as a problematization of anything "simple or straight-forward" (Mootoo 2017, 49), which informs a global paradigm for queer resistance: reorienting a view that familiarity is sovereign to straightness. Mootoo's writing simultaneously moves its meanings forward and sideways from a fixed orientation and, although García Zarranz's ethico-affective lens is critically useful, it may still fix the novel's narrative perspectives.

García Zarranz's lens could be expanded further, as a kaleidoscopic ethico-affective lens which could also shift and change to indicate the ability of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* to create a version of singularness which remains queerly communal. This kaleidoscopic lens conceptualizes the encounter among ethics, emotions, and relationships in the novel against the straightness of understanding one orientation as familiar.

This is an important distinction because it relies on Mootoo's literary queerness as the pivot that allows for a twist between different modes of "ethical encounters" and "relationality" (García Zarranz 2020, 94). It is a freedom from fixed ideas of what familiar belonging looks like that connects queerness with Mootoo, whose queer and Caribbean work creates a global mode of resistance. This means that queerness in *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* "problematizes normative" literary and social "scripts and orientations" (94), by familiarizing queerness, to become a rejection of the global condition of anti-queerness rather than one fixed only by a Caribbean location.

Disorienting narrative

Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab includes multiple stories and literary forms, including epistolary and metanarratives, creating and representing multiple perspectives. This manifold narrative form allows Mootoo to create a queer story that disorients objectivity: to depict the elusiveness of an objective truth as shared by the global population. For queer lives, Syd explains to Jonathan, disorientation can be a necessary camouflage against straight oppression. Syd explains that "if you think I am speaking in riddles" this is because "I don't know how else to speak", having "been trained" by the straight world "to hide my unease" (Mootoo 2017, 187). Emilio Amideo (2021) suggests that "Sydney's modality of storytelling" refuses "the binding of time" and "appears almost as a secret code of communication" (167). In my reading, this "code of communication" is not an intelligible form of relaying secret queer knowledge; rather, the disorientation created by recounting a queer story twists the concept of any shared intelligibility. Such twisting is a queer disorientation through a trans relationality when understood through a transfeminist mode, explained by Valencia and Arnaiz Zhuravleva as being "characterized by making strategic alliances that exceed the limits of traditional politics" (2019, 180). The trans narrative of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* connects more widely with the queerness of everyone who knows that the language, categorizations, semiotics, identities, and communities defined by a straight-dominated world do not describe them: disorientation is necessary to express a queer self against the straight world's terms. This is supported by Arnab Kumar Sinha's (2024) argument that Mootoo's novel "seeks to move beyond the fixed socio-cultural construct of traditional community" (99). Thus, Sydney decides to "tell my story as I must" and "in the only way I know how" (Mootoo 2017, 187), as a queer storytelling that twists the presentation of truth and refuses to be straightened into a shared point of view from a traditional community. This queer storytelling is a commitment to Ahmed's proposition for the communal connection possible in "queer use" where "we linger; we do not get to the point" (2019, 206). Perhaps "speaking in riddles" (Mootoo 2017, 187) can come closer to explaining, understanding, and embracing the unknowable complexity of lived experience, a life in which queers resist by lingering in a refusal to provide a straight-forward point.

I posit that forward and sideways remains an appropriate conceptual movement for Syd's queer relational shift, from Sid to Syd, to linger as queer use, against a straight-forward world. This is because Sid has always also been Syd, exemplified by Zain's description of Sid as always moving through life "sideways, sideways, like a crab" (Mootoo 2017, 102). This queer, crab-like movement through the world is a motif reflecting the queerness of natural forms and their inability to fit with demands to be

straight-forward. It remains key to Sid as a same-sex-desiring woman, and Syd as an opposite-sex-desiring man, navigating the global condition of anti-queerness between Trinidad and Canada within the reality that Sydney always exists within Siddhani. Interestingly, Zain, Sid's closest friend and unrequited love, always refers to Siddhani as Sid, meaning that Syd's queerness can be expressed in the past, present, and within the prolepsis of a narrative future, both forward and sideways. Mootoo's twisted use of perspective through Siddhani, Sid, Sydney, and Syd creates a polyvalent characterization where their queerness exists no matter their current embodiment in the narrative as either Sid or Syd.

However, Mootoo does not allow Zain's position as an ally or advocate for Syd to remain straight-forward or one-dimensional. Instead, it lies in her relational, and later financial, support of Syd's queer expression: using her privileges as a heterosexual cisgender woman to aid some aspects of Syd's personal expression. Despite her allyship with Syd, Zain also suggests that Sid straighten themself by imploring them to "learn to walk like me", meaning "like a cat" with "one foot in front of the other" (Mootoo 2017, 103). But Zain fails to comprehend that moving "sideways, like a crab" (102) cannot be made straight-forward without inflicting trauma on Syd. The trauma enacted on the self in attempts to straighten queer people exists as self-inflicted from the impositions of well-meaning others. Syd's queer relationship to the straight world is a resistance against it which remains embodied by those closest to her, because Syd's movement "like a crab" (102) reflects a queer engagement with the straight world to exercise his own autonomy. This singular, plural, and multiple queer engagement with the straight world remains explicit throughout *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab*, as Mootoo entwines Siddhani, Sid, Sydney, and Syd to disorient a perspective that one "ends" and another "begins". The polyvalent metanarratives related to Siddhani, Sid, Sydney, and Syd maintain their own movement "sideways, sideways like a crab" (102), by twisting forward and sideways against the demand for a straight-forward representation of gender transition as a phenomenon which takes place in one moment, or occurs in one life event.

Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab refuses to be fixed by literary identity, or expected literary movement, as a key characteristic of what I argue to be queer communality beyond community: in this instance, a queer Caribbean narrative refuses definition by anything except itself. To maintain its queer autonomy, I suggest that the novel enacts Mootoo's description of crab movement by simultaneously shifting forward through the straight world whilst moving sideways away from it. This movement is also indicative of the ways that a human body twists itself, by moving both forward and sideways to position itself in two directions: both towards and away from an object or subject. The narrative complexity of Mootoo's novel includes this spatial, perspectival, and temporal narrative twisting – moving forward and sideways – to represent past and present entwined through Sid and Syd, whilst continuing to highlight both "real" and imagined futures through Jonathan as a proxy narrator. This narrative complexity means that no part of the novel is easily divisible from its whole; however, its order also remains non-linear, non-chronological, both forward and sideways.

Just as Syd explains that Jonathan must "hear *all* the stories, in a seemingly digressive way, for *any* to make sense in the end", similarly "*all* the stories" of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* twist together to allow "*any* to make sense in the end" (Mootoo 2017, 122; emphasis in original). This reflects the reality that no one term of identity – no

one predetermined story about a person's identity – allows for the full complexities and embodiment of a unique and individual human being. This means that "*all* the stories" of a person should be validated beyond the bonds imposed by an identity. Acknowledging the irreducible complexity of everyone is continual personal work against straight-forwardness that demands or imposes a definition to categorize, and therefore reduce, the threat posed by individual difference to straight-forward order. The novel ensures that this complexity is represented by containing a past, present, and future chronotope twisted together to ensure a narrative flow that disorients a linear structure.

The narrative flow of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* remains in flux, against straight-forwardness, to frame Syd's story "as he [Syd] told it to me" (Mootoo 2017, 67). It produces a queer story that embraces disorientation because this is arguably closer to a natural global tempo that does not need to be straightened or ordered in codified terms. This literary disorientation moves against straight-forwardness regarding writerly autonomy, against postcolonial writing in colonial languages, as well as against the gender and sexual norms retained by nation language, as a twist forward and sideways across a Spivakian double bind, or an "aporia, which by definition cannot be crossed" (Spivak 2013, 104). I further suggest that this double bind incorporates the autonomy of queer writing in the straightness of colonial languages such as English, and that is arguably retained even in nation language, as Mootoo's queer Caribbean literary twists empower a discursive resistance to colonialism by resisting the retention of straightness in English and nation language. Thus, queerness is necessary to inform anti-colonial resistance through Spivak's imperative that we must be willing "to risk loss, relishing the power of others to constrain our interpretive 'will to know'" by empowering our own "very positivities that cannot be exhausted by us, the otherness that always exceeds us" (Spivak 2013, 202). The entwined queerness and Caribbeanness of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* are informed by a refusal to conform to anything that limits the depiction of "the otherness that always exceeds us"; to move forward through, and yet sideways against, the continuing colonialism of straight dominance in anglophone Caribbean writing despite conceptions of nation language. Mootoo succeeds in refusing the fixed perceptions that come with a literary identity defined by a shared similarity, even by those who may attempt to collect around a queer "identity" as something that has an essential characteristic, and which always remains a contradiction in terms because queerness is disidentifying. Returning to Muñoz's description, disidentification "tactically and simultaneously works on, with, and against a cultural form" (Muñoz 1999, 12). Thus, disidentifying can be viewed as of fundamental importance for defying the colonialism of categorization, by twisting against the straight-forwardness of identity.

Conclusion: Twisting détournement

In this article I have argued for the importance of conceptualizing a twist against straight-forwardness, because this remains part of the queerness necessary for an anti-colonial praxis. In my view, queer writing adds an additional twist on Édouard Glissant's ([1990] 2019, 40) interpretation of "rerouting [*détournement*]". Glissant originally conceptualized *détournement* through the francophone writing of Saint-

John Perse, and if Perse's rerouting functions in a francophone Caribbean context to enact a postcolonial resistance, then – reflecting Ahmed's conceptions of queer use – I propose that Mootoo adds further twists on *détournement* by instead moving forward through it, and sideways against it. For example, despite the differences that could be used to separate Mootoo from other queer Caribbean writers – related to cultural, identity, and community backgrounds – their writing is able to commune in Glissant's demand to have "nothing to do with any reference" ([1990] 2019, 40) to the colonialism of straightness in English literature, as well as demanding "nothing to do with any reference" that retains straightness in Caribbean literature. Despite its presupposed straightness, this does not mean that the body of Caribbean literature is rejected, but rather that Mootoo's writing is able to connect with Caribbean literary history because it includes a global scope when writing against straight-forwardness: disorientation and disidentification as anti-colonial praxes.

Such anti-colonial resistance lies in a queer Caribbean writing that not only subverts the racism of British colonialism but also resists its inseparability from contemporary straightness, which arguably remains in conceptions of nation language. Returning to my earlier manipulation of García Zarranz's ethico-affective lens, Mootoo multiplies Glissant's *détournement* by twisting it against the limits of straight-forwardness, a move that is of vital importance for queer and anti-colonial resistance to achieve a combined global resonance. It involves multiple reroutings, both forward and sideways, against the centrality of whiteness as tied to straightness, on global and local levels, which both inform and support the global condition of anti-queerness. Queer communality involves a stalwart commitment to going against the straight-forward grain. It means nurturing, harnessing, and applying your singular queer self as consistent with Ahmed's queer use, which requires "a certain willingness to be perverse, to deviate from the straight path, the right path" (2019, 201). Therefore, Mootoo retains a literary mode which is unique to a queer way of understanding cultural creation as a global phenomenon against a straight-forward path.

The queer Caribbean literary body of *Moving Forward Sideways Like a Crab* twists against straight-forwardness in a macrosocial version of queer resistance, because it always necessarily directly engages the social construction of race as inseparable from straightness, amid the global condition of anti-queerness. These queer twists can conceptually travel beyond the Caribbean, because their queer Caribbeanness is anti-colonial, which allows them to become global in scope. It is possible, in turn, that anglophone Caribbean writing has always been moving queerly, if it has sought to defy colonial, neocolonial, and postcolonial paradigms of contemporary power. Queer communality aids in understanding the additional queer twists necessary for an anti-colonial praxis to be realized, and further echoes queer Caribbean writer Shivanee Ramlochan's (2020) declaration that "reading the Caribbean means you read the world" (n.p.). Thus, Mootoo's writing represents the ways that interconnections of queer Caribbean writing continue to add to nascent conceptions of what anti-colonial resistance is, and what it can be, globally moving forward and, of course, sideways.

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Notes on contributor

Tom Lockwood-Moran (he/they) earned his PhD from Nottingham Trent University (NTU) in December 2024. His thesis argued that contemporary anglophone Caribbean writings form a communality for global queer literary resistance via movements, relationalities, and modes. Supervised across NTU and the University of Leicester, his research was funded by the UK's Arts and Humanities Research Council. He has been an adjunct lecturer for all stages of undergraduate English study, and a teaching assistant on postgraduate English modules. He is currently developing a monograph proposal from his thesis alongside forthcoming journal articles.

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